

TEACHING SCRIPT | LESSON 7

1 Thessalonians, Part 2

A 50-minute teaching script for 1 Thessalonians 4–5

BEFORE CLASS Write on the board: How should Christ's return change the way we live today? Have 1 Thessalonians 4:1–12; 4:13–18; 5:1–11; and 5:23–24 marked for one reader.

BIG IDEA Because Christ will return and raise his people, believers pursue holiness, love, hope, and watchful faithfulness.

0:00–4:00 | Welcome, prayer, and Lesson 6 recap

Good morning. Last week we saw that the gospel became visible in Thessalonica. Their faith worked, their love labored, and their hope endured—even under pressure. The Lord's message rang out because people could hear the gospel and see the change it produced.

Today Paul shows us where that hope points and how it shapes ordinary life. He addresses sexual holiness, love, work, grief, Christ's return, congregational care, discernment, and sanctification. That may sound like seven lessons trying to sneak into one coat. Paul holds them together with one conviction: Jesus will return for his people.

Our board question is: How should Christ's return change the way we live today?

Let's pray. Holy Spirit, teach us through your Word. Fix our hope on Jesus Christ. Comfort those who grieve, expose empty speculation, and form in us the holy and loving life that belongs to the coming day. Amen.

4:00–8:00 | Orient the class to chapters 4–5

Only some of us may have completed both chapters, so here is the road map. Paul first describes a life pleasing to God. He then answers concern about Christians who have died and reminds the church that the Day of the Lord calls for readiness, not date-setting. He closes with instructions for congregational life and a prayer that God will sanctify them completely.

Notice the sequence: God's future gives shape to the church's present. Resurrection hope does not pull believers out of ordinary life. It changes how they use their bodies, love neighbors, do their work, grieve, treat one another, and discern what is true.

8:00–11:00 | Read 1 Thessalonians 4:1–12

Ask one reader to read 1 Thessalonians 4:1–12. Ask everyone to listen for the phrases “God's will,” “more and more,” and “so that.”

11:00–16:00 | Holiness, love, work, and witness

Paul begins with encouragement. They already know how to live in order to please God, and they are living that way. His command is to do so “more and more.” A faithful church is not a finished church.

“It is God's will that you should be sanctified.” Paul immediately applies sanctification to sexual conduct. The surrounding culture offered many ways to separate sexuality from covenant faithfulness. Paul calls believers to self-control, holiness, and honor. Sexual sin does not remain private; it wrongs other people and rejects the God who gives his Holy Spirit.

Then Paul turns to brotherly love. God has taught them to love one another, and their love is already spreading through Macedonia. Again, Paul says, “do so more and more.” Grace does not make growth unnecessary; grace makes growth possible.

Verse 11 sounds almost ordinary: aspire to live quietly, mind your own affairs, and work with your hands. This is not permission to withdraw from mission. It is a call to steady, responsible life so that outsiders see honorable conduct and believers do not create needless dependence.

ASK Why might Paul place sexual holiness, brotherly love, ordinary work, and public witness in the same paragraph?

16:00–19:00 | Read 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18

Ask the reader to read 4:13–18. Ask the class to listen for the Thessalonians' concern, the gospel fact Paul uses to answer it, and his final command.

19:00–24:00 | Grief transformed by the gospel

Paul does not say Christians should not grieve. Death is an enemy, separation hurts, and Jesus himself wept. Paul says believers do not grieve “like the rest of mankind, who have no hope.” Christian grief is real grief governed by a different future.

The foundation appears in verse 14: “We believe that Jesus died and rose again.” Paul does not begin with a chart. He begins with the gospel. Because Jesus died and rose, those who belong to him will not be abandoned to death.

Paul calls deceased believers those who “sleep.” That was a familiar way to speak about death, but it becomes especially fitting in light of resurrection. Sleep is temporary. The image should not be forced to answer every question about the believer’s condition between death and resurrection.

24:00–29:00 | The Lord comes and gathers his people

The Thessalonians seem to fear that believers who died before Christ’s return will miss something. Paul’s answer is emphatic: the living will not precede them. The Lord will descend, the dead in Christ will rise first, and living believers will be caught up together with them to meet the Lord.

This is where Christians often begin constructing competing timelines. Paul’s emphasis is simpler and more pastoral. The dead are not disadvantaged. The living do not leave them behind. The whole people of Christ are gathered together, and “so we will be with the Lord forever.”

The word “rapture” comes through the Latin translation of “caught up.” The catching up is in the text. A complete system describing how this moment relates to every other end-times passage is not. We should not ask this paragraph to answer questions Paul was not answering.

And notice Paul’s conclusion: “Therefore encourage one another with these words.” If our interpretation produces pride, panic, or endless quarrels but not encouragement, we have missed Paul’s pastoral destination.

ASK What changes when we begin this passage with Christian grief rather than with an end-times chart?

29:00–32:00 | Read 1 Thessalonians 5:1–11

Ask the reader to read 5:1–11. Ask everyone to listen for what Paul says they do not need, who believers already are, and what they should do.

32:00–38:00 | The Day of the Lord and watchful faithfulness

Paul says they do not need more information about “times and dates.” The Day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night—unexpectedly—and like labor pains—suddenly and unavoidably. The point is not that nobody can ever discuss biblical signs. The point is that no calculated schedule can substitute for readiness.

Then Paul moves from event to identity: “You are not in darkness.” “You are all children of the light and children of the day.” Because of who God has made them, they must stay awake and sober.

Watchfulness is not staring nervously at the sky. Paul describes it with faith, love, and hope. Faith and love form a breastplate; the hope of salvation is a helmet. The same three marks praised in chapter 1 now equip the church for the coming day.

The gospel center appears in verses 9–10: God did not appoint us to suffer wrath but to receive salvation through Jesus Christ. Christ died for us so that, whether alive or dead when he comes, we may live together with him.

Paul ends exactly as he did in 4:18: “Therefore encourage one another and build each other up.” Biblical teaching about Christ’s return should create a steadier, braver, more encouraging church.

38:00–44:00 | A waiting church lives together

Summarize 5:12–22. Paul now gives a rapid series of commands that show what readiness looks like in congregational life.

Respect those who labor and lead. Live at peace. Warn the idle, encourage the discouraged, help the weak, and be patient with everyone. Notice that people need different kinds of care. Treating everyone identically is not always the same as loving everyone faithfully.

Reject retaliation and pursue what is good. Rejoice, pray, and give thanks. These commands do not deny suffering; they describe a life anchored in Christ within suffering.

Then Paul says, “Do not quench the Spirit” and “do not treat prophecies with contempt,” but also, “test them all; hold on to what is good, reject every kind of evil.” The church must resist two opposite errors: dismissing every claimed work of the Spirit and accepting every spiritual claim without discernment. Openness and testing belong together.

44:00–47:00 | Read and teach 1 Thessalonians 5:23–24

Ask the reader to read 5:23–24.

After giving all these commands, Paul prays. “May God himself, the God of peace, sanctify you through and through.” Christian obedience is serious, but the final hope of sanctification is not our ability to repair ourselves.

Verse 24 may be the gospel anchor for this entire lesson: “The one who calls you is faithful, and he will do it.” The God who calls his people also preserves and transforms them as they await Christ.

47:00–50:00 | The Gospel Then and Now

Return to the board: How should Christ’s return change the way we live today?

The Thessalonians faced sexual pressure, grief, uncertainty, disruptive behavior, and ordinary congregational strain. Paul did not treat Christ’s return as an escape from those realities. Resurrection hope reshaped their response to them.

Churches now can detach prophecy from discipleship. We may chase dates, defend systems, frighten people, or argue over sequences while neglecting holiness, love, work, discernment, patience, and encouragement. Paul moves in the opposite direction: because Jesus died, rose, and will return, encourage one another and live as children of the coming day.

Before next week, start with 2 Thessalonians 1 and 2:1–17. If possible, read the entire three-chapter letter. Notice how Paul addresses persecution, confusion about the Day of the Lord, and disorderly living.

Let’s pray. God of peace, thank you that Jesus died and rose and will gather all who belong to him. Comfort those who grieve. Make us holy in body and spirit. Teach us to love, work, pray, test what we hear, and encourage one another. You are faithful; complete your work in us until Christ comes. Amen.

FINAL LINE Because Jesus died, rose, and will return, the church grieves with hope, lives as children of light, and encourages one another while the faithful God makes his people holy.